

Down 44% per person, or off track for 2030?

Testing a public claim about Malta's greenhouse-gas emissions against EU and Eurostat data

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

“Emissions per capita have fallen by 44% since 2005, well above the EU average of 34%.”

Climate Action Authority, press release, 13 November 2025.

Citing the European Commission's Climate Action Progress Report 2025.

VERDICT: MISLEADING

Accurate figures; the report's main finding is left out

TL;DR

Malta’s Climate Action Authority (CAA) said in November 2025 that **emissions per person have fallen 44% since 2005, well above the EU average of 34%**, citing the European Commission’s 2025 Climate Action Progress Report. **Ranked against all 27 Member States, Malta’s per-person cut to 2024 is the 3rd largest; its cut in total emissions is the 20th.** In the sectors under its binding national target, the same Commission report shows Malta over its yearly limit by 22 to 30 points in each year from 2022 to 2024, and projects that it will miss its 2030 target by the widest margin in the EU in percentage points. The release mentions neither.

- 1

The numbers are right. Eurostat data reproduce a per-person fall of about 46% (2005–2023) for Malta against 34% for the EU.
- 2

Per person 3rd in the EU, in total 20th. Malta’s population grew 41%, second only to Luxembourg; about half of the per-person fall is population growth. Total emissions fell 27% (EU 33%; Figure 2).
- 3

Nearly all of the cut came from power generation, which is outside the national target (–63%). Transport rose 49%, buildings 9% and refrigerant gases almost six-fold.
- 4

Over the yearly limit since 2022. Effort-sharing emissions (transport, buildings, waste, farming, F-gases) were 41–43% above 2005 in 2022–2024, against limits of +21% to +11%. A large 2021 allocation has covered the overshoot until 2024; the balance is projected at –2.1 Mt by 2030 (Figure 4), and even with planned measures at +30% against a –19% target.
- 5

Two points in the authority’s favour. Per person, target-sector emissions are flat (2.50 t in 2005, 2.52 t in 2024; our estimate), and no compliance shortfall has arisen yet: the first check is in 2027.
- 6

Verdict: misleading (high confidence). Each figure is accurate, but citing the per-person result from the report while omitting its central finding on Malta leaves an inaccurate overall impression.

THIS CLAIM

SUPPORTED

LARGELY SUPPORTED

NOT SUBSTANTIATED

MISLEADING

CONTRADICTED

–44%

Per-person change since 2005, as stated by the CAA (EU –34%)

3rd / 20th

Malta’s EU-27 rank on the per-person cut / on the cut in total emissions, 2005–2024

+30 pts

Over the yearly effort-sharing limit in 2024 (+41% vs +11% on 2005)

49 pts

Projected 2030 gap to the effort-sharing target, with planned measures

WHAT WOULD MOVE THE VERDICT UP

A published path taking effort-sharing emissions from +41% to –19% by 2030; evidence that the projections are out of date; or a statement that put the per-person figure next to the 2030 projection.

WHAT WOULD MOVE IT DOWN

Evidence that the per-person figure is used in place of the target metric in other official communications, or that Malta plans to rely mainly on buying allocations from other states.

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v1.2 draft · 5 October 2026 · pending right of reply

2

1 The claim and what we could verify

The claim is the Climate Action Authority’s own press release of 13 November 2025 [1], read in full from an archived copy. MaltaToday reported it the same week, quoting the authority [2]. A news-agency report on the same EU publication led instead with Malta’s projected 2030 increase [3]. We assess the authority’s wording, not the headlines.

Source	What it says	Our access	Status
Climate Action Authority , press release, 13 Nov 2025 [1]	“Emissions per capita have fallen by 44% since 2005, well above the EU average of 34%.” Emissions per unit of GDP down 81.6% (EU 61.9%). The figures “show that Malta is reducing emissions both at household level and across the economy, while continuing to grow.” Transport and buildings named as sectors “where challenges remain”. No mention of the 2030 projection.	Read in full (Wayback copy, 15 Apr 2026). Live site blocks automated access.	The claim
MaltaToday , Nov 2025 [2]	Repeats the authority’s figures and quotes it.	Read in full (Wayback copy).	Relay
Italpress / MNA , 17 Nov 2025 [3]	Same EU report: Malta’s emissions to rise about 30% above 2005 by 2030 against a 19% cut, a gap of 49 points; per-person fall of 44% also reported.	Read in full.	Context
European Commission , CAPR 2025 staff working document [4] and chapter 3 [5]	Malta’s effort-sharing emissions and projections; sector trends; Malta among the three Member States with the largest projected 2030 gaps.	Read: all Malta passages.	Primary evidence
CAA factsheet , June 2026	Listed in our candidate file as the authority’s framing.	Not read: blocked, no archived copy.	Gap

FAIRNESS NOTE

Malta’s power-sector transformation is real and large: emissions from electricity generation fell by almost two-thirds after the Malta–Sicily interconnector (2015) and the conversion of Delimara to gas. Per-person and per-GDP indicators are legitimate and the Commission publishes them. The release also says transport and buildings remain challenging. This check is about what the release leaves out, not about whether the indicators are valid.

2 Method

Question. Is the per-person comparison accurate, and does it give a fair picture of Malta’s progress on emissions as the same EU report assesses it?

Evidence. This claim is statistical, so independent datasets carry most of the weight. We downloaded Eurostat greenhouse-gas inventories (env_air_gge), population (nama_10_pe) and renewables shares (nrg_ind_ren) on 2 October 2026, and the same emissions and population series for all 27 Member States on 5 October 2026, and recomputed every percentage with a script (*tools/cc-003-report/calc.py*; outputs in *data/cc-003/*). Malta’s effort-sharing figures are typed from the Commission’s Tables 25 and 26 into *data/cc-003/capr2025_esr_malta.csv*. We read every passage on Malta in the Commission’s staff working document. Peer-reviewed literature was searched for Malta-specific decompositions of emissions; none was found (Section 8).

Grades. Official statistics and EU assessments are grade C under our scale (official statistics summary). The two peer-reviewed papers on Maltese transport are context only. **Verdicts** follow the five-point scale in Appendix A.

3 Why per person and total differ

Emissions per person are total emissions divided by population. If the population grows, the per-person figure falls even when total emissions do not change. This is the identity behind the “impact = population × impact per person” framing used in environmental science since the 1970s [12 ♦]. Malta’s population grew 41% over the period, second only to Luxembourg (+46%) in the EU, so the two measures diverge more for Malta than for almost any other state.

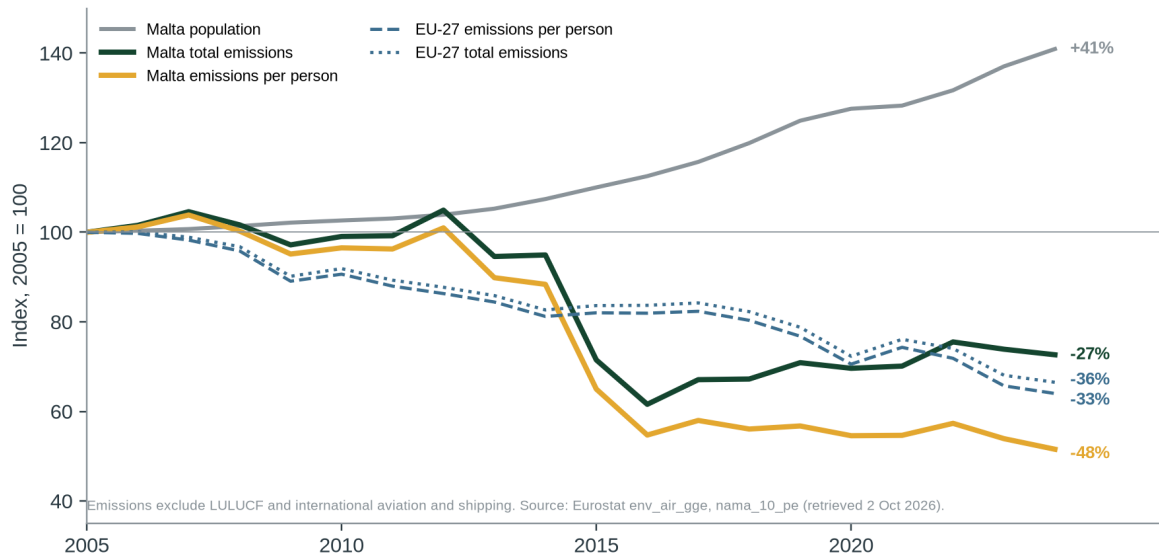


Figure 1. Malta’s total emissions, population and emissions per person, indexed to 2005, with EU-27 for comparison. Per-person emissions fell further than total emissions because the denominator rose 41%.

THE ARITHMETIC

Total emissions: 2.99 Mt (2005) to 2.17 Mt (2024), –27%. Population: 404,000 to 569,000, +41%. Per person: 7.4 t to 3.8 t, –48%. On a logarithmic split, **52% of the per-person fall is explained by population growth** and 48% by lower total emissions. For the EU, population grew 4% and per-person and total falls are nearly the same.

EU-27, 2005–2024: Malta’s cut ranks 3rd per person but 20th in total

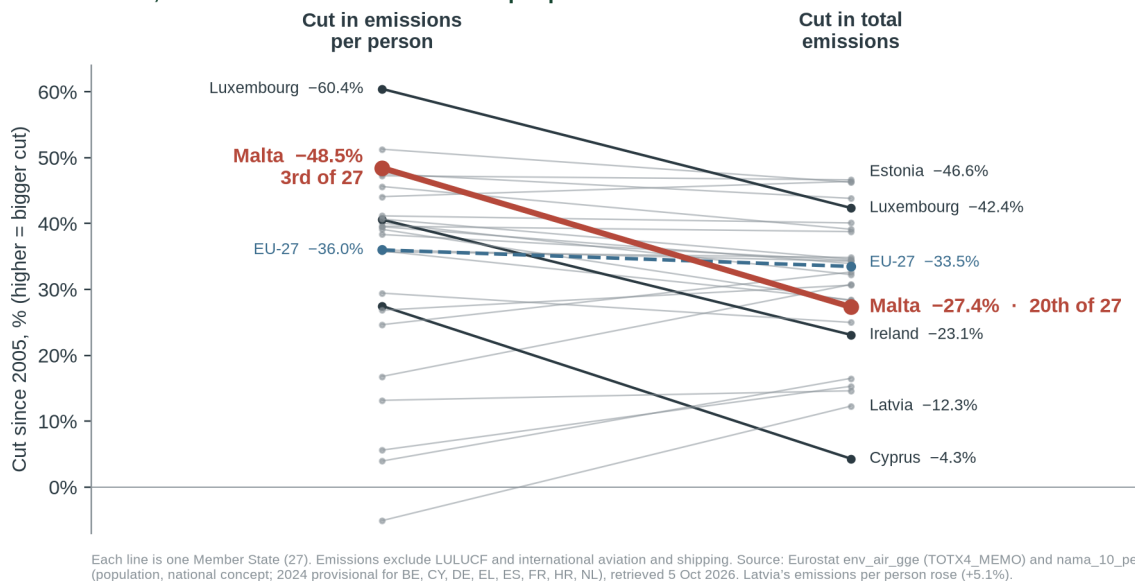


Figure 2. Cut in emissions, 2005–2024, per person (left) and in total (right), all 27 Member States. The steeper a line falls, the more population growth flattered its per-person cut.

Ranking all 27 Member States both ways shows how much the choice of measure matters (Figure 2). Malta’s per-person cut, –48.5% to 2024, is the third largest, behind Luxembourg and Denmark. Its cut in total emissions,

–27.4%, is the 20th. No other state falls as far between the two rankings (17 places; next Ireland, 12, and Cyprus, 7); all three are among the four fastest-growing populations in the EU (Malta +41%, Cyprus +32%, Ireland +29%).

4 What the data show

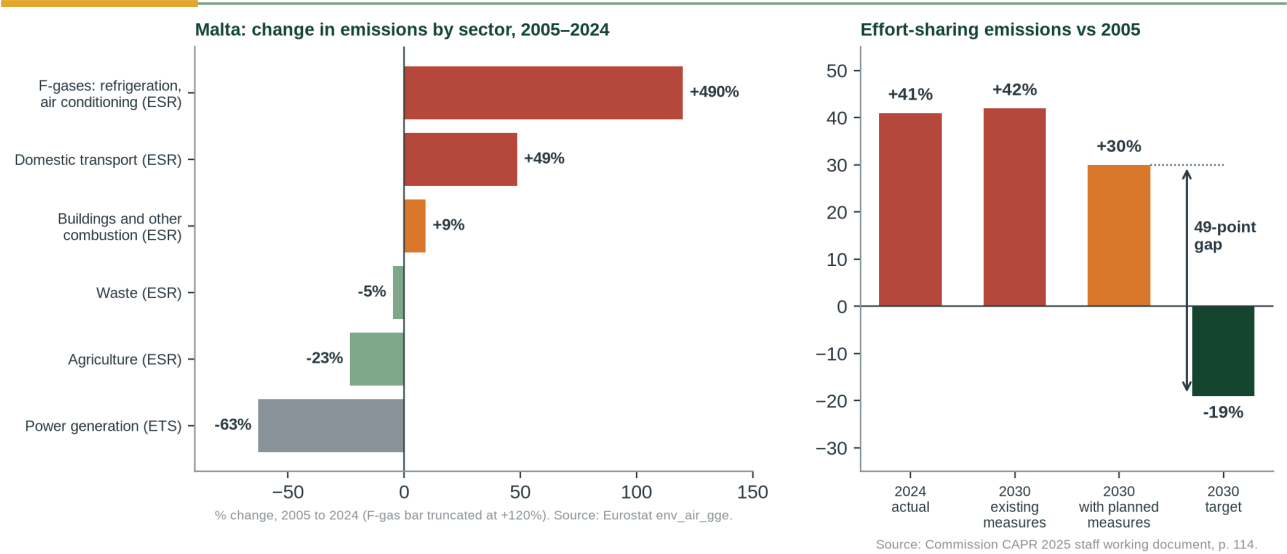


Figure 3. Left: emissions by sector, Malta, 2005–2024 (Eurostat). Power generation is covered by the EU Emissions Trading System (ETS); the other sectors count towards Malta's national effort-sharing target. Right: effort-sharing emissions relative to 2005 and the 2030 target (Commission).

Indicator	Malta	EU-27	Source	Grade
Per-person emissions, 2005–2023	–46%	–34%	Eurostat [6, 7]; CAA cites –44% / –34% [1]	C
Total emissions, 2005–2024	–27%	–33%	Eurostat [6]	C
Population, 2005–2024	+41%	+4%	Eurostat [7]	C
Power generation emissions, 2005–2024	–63%	–54%	Eurostat [6]	C
Domestic transport emissions, 2005–2024	+49%	–5%	Eurostat [6]; Commission [4] pp. 51–52	C
Industrial emissions (mainly refrigeration and air-conditioning gases), 2005–2023	+293%	–36%	Commission [4] p. 44	C
Buildings emissions since 2005	+12%	fell in every other state but Romania	Commission [4] p. 59	C
Effort-sharing emissions, 2024 vs 2005	+41%	–20%	Commission [4] pp. 114–115	C
2030 projection, existing measures / with planned measures	+42% / +30%	–31% / –38%	Commission [4] pp. 114–115	C
2030 effort-sharing target	–19%	–40% (EU)	Commission [4] pp. 114–115	C
Effort-sharing emissions vs yearly limit, 2022 / 2023 / 2024	+43 / +42 / +41% vs +21 / +16 / +11%	2024: –20% vs –21%	Commission [4] pp. 114–115	C
Cumulative allocation balance, 2024 / 2030 projected	0.0 / –2.1 Mt	–	Commission [4] p. 125	C

Indicator	Malta	EU-27	Source	Grade
Effort-sharing emissions per person, 2005 → 2024 (our estimate)	2.50 → 2.52 t	about –23%	Eurostat [6, 7]; Commission [4]	C
Renewables share of electricity, 2024	10.7%	47.5%	Eurostat [8]	C

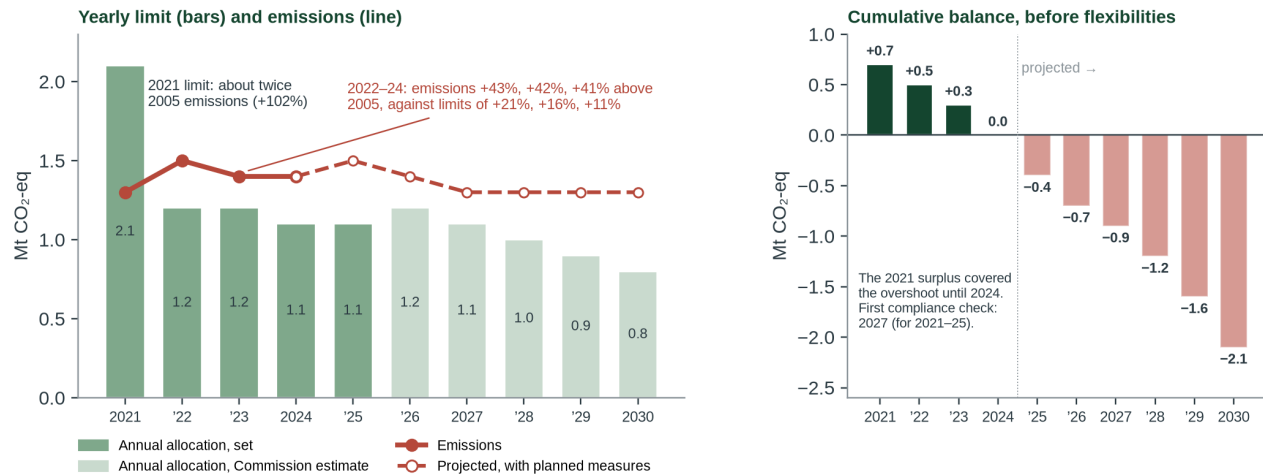
All values recomputed or transcribed in data/cc-003/checks.csv. The Commission’s per-person series uses net emissions and an earlier inventory; ours uses the 2026 inventory excluding land use, so small differences are expected. Effort-sharing per person: Malta’s national total minus power generation (see below); EU from the Commission’s –20% and Eurostat population.

Reading across the data

- **The cut was concentrated in electricity**, which is regulated at EU level through the ETS and does not count towards Malta’s national 2030 target.
- **The sectors closest to households rose**: cars, buildings and air-conditioning gases. The release’s phrase “reducing emissions both at household level” is not what the sector data show; a per-person ratio is not a measure of household emissions.
- **Malta’s 2030 gap is the largest in the EU in percentage points**: 61 points with existing measures and 49 with planned measures. The next largest is Ireland (33 and 20) [4]. In tonnes, larger states’ gaps are bigger: Germany’s projected 2030 shortfall is 64 Mt CO₂-eq, Malta’s 0.5 Mt [4, pp. 118, 125]. The Commission names Germany, Ireland and Malta as having the largest projected gaps [5].
- **International shipping and aviation bunkers**, which are outside both the national total and the target, tripled from 2.4 to 7.3 Mt, more than three times Malta’s national total. They are reported but not part of this claim.

Malta against its yearly limits

Under the Effort Sharing Regulation each Member State has a binding limit for every year from 2021, its annual emission allocation. Malta’s 2021 allocation was set at about twice its 2005 emissions (+102%); its emissions that year were 30% above 2005, leaving a surplus of 0.7 Mt. From 2022 the limits are much tighter, +21%, +16% and +11%, while emissions stayed at 41–43% above 2005: 22, 25 and 30 points over [4, p. 114]. Counting the 2021 surplus against the later overshoots, the Commission’s cumulative balance falls to 0.0 Mt in 2024 and, on projections with planned measures, to –2.1 Mt by 2030 (Figure 4) [4, p. 125]. Compliance is first checked in 2027, for 2021–2025, when states may use flexibilities such as buying allocations from other states; Malta also has 0.5 Mt of ETS flexibility for the decade [4, pp. 111, 125].



Source: European Commission, Climate Action Progress Report 2025 staff working document, Table 26 (p. 125; values rounded to 0.1 Mt; later years are projections with planned measures; transfers and cancellations not counted) and Table 25 (p. 114, percentages). Malta also has 0.5 Mt of ETS flexibility for 2021–2030.

Figure 4. Malta’s effort-sharing sectors: yearly allocations and emissions (left) and the running balance (right), from the Commission’s Table 26, which rounds to 0.1 Mt. Years after 2024 are projections.

FAIRNESS NOTE: TWO POINTS IN THE AUTHORITY'S FAVOUR

Per person, the target sectors are flat. Eurostat does not publish effort-sharing emissions, so we estimate them as Malta's national total minus power generation. This stand-in matches the Commission closely: 1.01 Mt in 2005 (Commission base 1.0 Mt) and changes to 2021–2024 of +31%, +44%, +39% and +42% (Commission +30%, +43%, +42%, +41%). On it, emissions in these sectors were 2.50 t per person in 2005 and 2.52 t in 2024. The 41% rise therefore reflects 41% more people, not each resident emitting more. They did not fall either: across the EU, effort-sharing emissions per person fell by about 23% (Commission –20%, population +4%).

No shortfall has been incurred yet. The 2021 surplus has covered the overshoot so far, and compliance is first assessed in 2027. The projections show the problem ahead, not a breach already made.

5 Where the evidence points different ways

Three questions decide how the per-person figure should be read. Each sets out the case for the authority's framing beside the case against.

Q1 Is per person a fair way to compare Malta with the EU?

BOTH VALID, NOT INTERCHANGEABLE

EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION

Per-person emissions are a standard indicator, published by the Commission itself [4]. They allow small and large states to be compared and reflect equity arguments in climate policy.

EVIDENCE AGAINST

Malta's binding EU obligation is expressed in total tonnes against 2005, not per person. With the second-fastest population growth in the EU, the per-person figure flatters Malta more than any other state: it ranks 3rd per person and 20th in total (Figure 2).

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

Per person and total answer different questions. **For this claim:** the release uses the per-person result as evidence that Malta's efforts are "showing clear results" without saying that, in total tonnes, Malta cut less than the EU average.

Q2 Do the results reflect policy, or one-off changes?

MAINLY ONE STRUCTURAL CHANGE

EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION

The interconnector and the gas conversion were policy decisions, and they delivered a lasting 63% cut in power-sector emissions. Emissions per unit of GDP fell 82% [1, 4].

EVIDENCE AGAINST

Outside power generation, emissions grew. Effort-sharing sectors were 30% above 2005 already in 2021 and 41% above in 2024 [4]. Transport and car ownership growth on islands is a known structural problem [10, 11].

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

For this claim: the headline result is real but comes from the sector that is not under the national target. The sectors that are under it have moved away from the target.

Q3 Can the 2030 gap still be closed?

UNCERTAIN; PROJECTIONS SAY NO

EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION

The CAA says Malta aims to cut emissions by 40% by 2030 [1]. No shortfall has been incurred yet: the 2021 surplus covers 2022–2024, and compliance is first checked in 2027 [4, pp. 111, 125]. The EU rules allow flexibilities (buying allocations from other states, ETS and land-use credits). Projections can be revised as measures are added.

EVIDENCE AGAINST

Malta has been 22–30 points over its yearly limit since 2022 [4, p. 114]. Even with planned measures the Commission projects +30% against –19% [4]. The cumulative allocation balance turns negative from 2025 and reaches –2.1 Mt by 2030 before flexibilities [4, p. 125]. Malta is among six states projected to have excess emissions in 2026–2030 [5].

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

We did not test the 40% figure; it appears to refer to total emissions including power, while the binding target covers the sectors that are rising. **For this claim:** a reader of the release would not learn that the gap exists.

6 Testing the claim

Sub-claim	Said by	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. Emissions per capita have fallen 44% since 2005	CAA [1]	Reproduced from Eurostat (–46% to 2023, –48% to 2024). Commission source.	ACCURATE
B. ...well above the EU average of 34%	CAA [1]	Reproduced (–34% to 2023). True per person (3rd of 27 to 2024); not in total tonnes (–27% vs –33%; 20th of 27).	ACCURATE, PARTIAL
C. Emissions per unit of GDP down 81.6% vs EU 61.9%	CAA [1]	Not recomputed (GDP series and price base not stated). Direction consistent with Commission data.	NOT TESTED
D. Malta is reducing emissions at household level	CAA [1]	In total, sectors linked to households rose: transport +49%, buildings +9 to +12%, air-conditioning gases up almost six-fold. Per person, the target sectors were flat (2.50 t to 2.52 t, our estimate), not falling. A per-person ratio of all emissions is not a household measure.	NOT SUPPORTED
E. Malta's efforts are showing clear results	CAA [1]	True for power generation. The same report shows Malta over its yearly limits since 2022 and projects the largest shortfall in the EU (in percentage points) against its binding 2030 target; the release mentions neither.	MISLEADING BY OMISSION
F. Malta aims to reduce emissions by 40% by 2030	CAA [1]	A stated aim, not a result. Scope (total or effort-sharing) not given. Same figure appears in the 2026 Labour manifesto (see CC-011).	UNCLEAR SCOPE

WHAT THE REPORT ITSELF SAYS ABOUT MALTA

The CAA release cites the Commission's November 2025 report as its source. In the staff working document, Malta's effort-sharing table (p. 114) shows emissions 22, 25 and 30 points above the yearly limits in 2022–2024, +41% in 2024, and a projected 2030 gap of 61 points with existing measures and 49 with planned ones. The web chapter on effort sharing names Malta among the three states with the largest projected gaps [5]. Choosing the per-person line from that report, and leaving out the target line, is the pattern our methodology calls a *selective metric*.

7 Verdict and requests for evidence

VERDICT

MISLEADING

Accurate figures, inaccurate overall impression. Confidence: high. Based on the Commission's own report and Eurostat data, both of which can be shown.

Why. (1) The 44% and 34% figures are correct and reproducible. (2) About half of Malta's per-person fall reflects population growth; in total tonnes Malta cut less than the EU average, and its rank falls from 3rd to 20th of 27. (3) The cut came almost entirely from power generation, which is outside the national target, while transport, buildings and refrigerant gases rose. (4) The report the authority cites shows Malta over its yearly limits since 2022 and projects that it will miss its binding 2030 target by the widest margin in the EU in percentage points; the release omits this. Under our scale, a statement whose individual figures are defensible but which omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate is *Misleading*.

What this verdict does not say. It does not say the figures are false, that the power-sector transition was not an achievement, that Malta has already broken EU rules (the 2021 surplus has covered the overshoot so far, and compliance is first checked in 2027), or that anyone acted in bad faith. A fuller statement would read: "*Emissions per person fell 44%, helped by strong population growth; total emissions fell 27%. Emissions in transport, buildings and*

other effort-sharing sectors are 41% above 2005, and the Commission projects we will miss our 2030 target unless we do more.”

Evidence we are asking for

- ☐ The Climate Action Authority's source for the 44% and 34% figures (table, year and emissions scope).
- ☐ The scope of the “40% by 2030” aim: total emissions, effort-sharing emissions, or another basis.
- ☐ The latest projection of effort-sharing emissions for 2030, and the measures and dates that close the gap to –19%.
- ☐ Whether Malta expects to use flexibilities (purchased allocations, ETS or land-use credits) to meet the target, and in what quantity.
- ☐ The June 2026 CAA emissions factsheet, which we could not access.

RIGHT OF REPLY

Before wider circulation this draft should be sent to the Climate Action Authority and the Ministry for the Environment, Energy and Public Cleanliness with a fixed deadline (suggested 14 days). Under our standards a *Misleading* verdict is not published before that deadline passes. Responses will be appended and the verdict revisited.

8

Limitations

- This is a statistical check. Peer-reviewed literature was searched (Crossref, OpenAlex) for Malta-specific decompositions of emissions; none was found, so the decomposition here is our own two-factor arithmetic.
- Eurostat's 2026 inventory differs slightly from the 2025 inventory the Commission used; we reproduce the direction and size of the CAA's figures, not the exact decimals.
- Projections are the Commission's reading of Malta's 2025 submissions; newer measures may change them.
- Effort-sharing emissions per person are our estimate (national total minus power generation), not an official series; they match the Commission's 2005 base and its 2021–2024 changes within 3 points. The Commission's Table 26 rounds to 0.1 Mt, so a balance of 0.0 Mt in 2024 means within about 0.05 Mt of zero, and its cumulative balance ignores transfers and cancellations [4, p. 116].
- The EU-27 ranking uses 2024 population figures that Eurostat marks provisional for eight states (not Malta).
- We read the transport papers [10, 11] as abstracts only; they are context, not evidence for the verdict.
- The CAA's June 2026 factsheet could not be read. If it presents the 2030 gap, that would be relevant to how the authority communicates, though not to the November 2025 release assessed here.

References

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- [12] Ehrlich P.R., Holdren J.P. (1971). Impact of population growth. *Science* 171(3977):1212–1217. doi:10.1126/science.171.3977.1212. (Cited for the identity only; not read.)

Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate:** evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low:** evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient · C review, guidance or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. ♦ marks a source known only second-hand.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline**, with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it**, and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify**, and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.
- **Offer a right of reply** before wider circulation and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	2 Oct 2026	First issue. Draft pending right of reply from the Climate Action Authority and the Ministry for the Environment, Energy and Public Cleanliness.
1.1	5 Oct 2026	Corrections. (1) Section 4 table, EU 2030 effort-sharing projection: “–31% / ...” → “–31% / –38%” (existing / additional measures, Commission Table 25). (2) EU industrial emissions, 2005–2023: “fell” → “–36%” (Commission p. 44). (3) “Widest margin in the EU” → “widest margin in the EU in percentage points” (TL;DR, Sections 6 and 7, flyer); Section 4 adds that in tonnes Germany’s projected 2030 shortfall (64 Mt) exceeds Malta’s (0.5 Mt). (4) Commission page numbers changed from PDF to printed pages: p. 115 → pp. 114–115 (Figure 2 label → p. 114), p. 126 → 125, p. 45 → 44, p. 52 → 51–52, p. 60 → 59. (5) Flyer title “Emissions down 44%” → “Emissions per person down 44%”; the two “+41%” flyer cards retitled “Population growth since 2005” and “Target-sector emissions, 2024”. (6) data/cc-003/checks.csv now also holds the EU-27 values shown in the Section 4 table. Verdict and confidence unchanged.
1.2	5 Oct 2026	Upgrade: (1) New Figure 2 ranks all 27 Member States on the per-person and the total cut, 2005–2024 (Eurostat): Malta 3rd (–48.5%) and 20th (–27.4%). (2) New Figure 4 and a subsection on Malta’s yearly effort-sharing limits from the Commission’s Tables 25 and 26: 22, 25 and 30 points over in 2022–2024; cumulative balance 0.0 Mt in 2024, –2.1 Mt projected for 2030. (3) Fairness note: per-person emissions in the target sectors are flat (2.50 t to 2.52 t; our estimate, tested against the Commission’s figures), and no shortfall has been incurred before the first compliance check in 2027. (4) TL;DR, key points, tiles, Sections 3–8, flyer and data updated; old Figure 2 is now Figure 3. Verdict and confidence unchanged.